

other words, being born into a rich family or a poor family mattered less than if you were smart (as measured by IQ tests).²

Other researchers complained that Herrnstein and Murray had oversimplified socioeconomic status. They had included only parental income, occupation, and education. Adding in other social status indicators—family size, presence of two parents in the home, geographical residence, and so on—they found just the opposite: Socioeconomic status markers were more likely to be predictive than intelligence.

We don't know. And we don't care. Whatever you've got to work with is all you've got. Maybe your youthful socioeconomic status is a good forecast statistically, but so what? You make the most of what you've got. You don't care what the statistics tell you. What if they told you that your chances of success were less than those of someone down the block? Would you stop trying?

Probably the thing that makes one most successful in life is merely luck. As John D. Rockefeller put it, the way to success is to (1) get to work early, (2) stay late, and (3) strike oil. Give us a confident, energetic, ambitious young person, one whose natural pluck will put his luck to his advantage, and we will put our money on him, rather than on Old Money, any day.

But where do these qualities come from? And where's the fairness? Who knows? But some people are very troubled by the apparent unfairness of unearned money. And, in one sense, they are perhaps right. The system, at least in the United States, is rigged in their favor.

No, we don't mean by low tax rates; the rich still pay proportionately far more in taxes than the poor. The average top marginal federal tax rate imposed on the rich is 35 percent of income. Yet approximately half of all citizens have a net tax rate (net of money received from the government) of about zero. Where's the fairness in that?

But a lot of people feel guilty. They feel they have benefited unfairly, either because they personally did not earn their money or because the system benefited them at the expense of millions of others. While we probably agree with their analysis, we disagree with their conclusion. Yes, the rich did benefit from the government's lame-brained monetary and economic policies. Yes, the rich benefited from lower tax rates. Yes, many of the rich benefited from special favors given out by an increasingly